

Heuristic Evaluation Report: Coursera Usability Issues

To: Coursera UI/UX Improvement Team

Subject: Top 5 Usability Findings and Recommendations

Below is a streamlined report detailing the top 5 most critical usability issues found during a recent heuristic evaluation of the Coursera platform. These issues were evaluated against Nielsen's 10 Usability Heuristics. Each finding includes the location, severity, an elaborated description of the problem, a visual reference, and an actionable suggestion for improvement.

Finding 1: Hidden 'Audit' Course Option

Location: Course Enrollment Modal / Popup

Severity: 3 / 4

Heuristic(s) Violated: Recognition rather than recall; Aesthetic and minimalist design

Elaborated Description:

When attempting to enroll in a course for free, the primary CTA button prominently says 'Start Free Trial' (which leads to a credit card input). The option to 'Audit this course' is presented as a tiny, low-contrast text link hidden at the very bottom of the modal. According to Nielsen (nngroup.com), 'Recognition rather than recall' means making options, actions, and objects visible. By burying the free audit option, the design forces users to search extensively or mistakenly start a paid trial. The visual hierarchy manipulates the user rather than providing clear, visible choices.

Screenshot Reference:

[Screenshot: Cropped view of the Enrollment Popup, highlighting the massive 'Start Free Trial' button and the tiny, hard-to-see 'Audit' text link at the bottom.]

Suggestion for Improvement:

Make the 'Audit' option a secondary button rather than a hidden text link. For example, present the tracks side-by-side (e.g., 'Verified Certificate' vs. 'Full Audit') similar to how platforms like edX visually separate the two paths, ensuring users can clearly recognize their options.

Finding 2: Inconsistent Navigation Breadcrumbs

Location: Course and Specialization Navigation Sidebars

Severity: 3 / 4

Heuristic(s) Violated: Consistency and standards

Elaborated Description:

The left navigation sidebar behaves completely differently when viewing a Specialization home page versus a specific Course home page. When users click into a course from a specialization, they often lose the ability to easily navigate back, as the parent links disappear. Nielsen's heuristic 'Consistency and standards' states that 'Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing.' Breaking the navigation model across similar page hierarchies causes users to feel lost and resort to the browser's back button.

Screenshot Reference:

[Screenshot: Two side-by-side cropped screenshots showing the left sidebar on a Specialization page vs a Course page, with a red box pointing out the missing 'Back to Specialization' link.]

Suggestion for Improvement:

Implement persistent breadcrumb navigation at the top of all course pages (e.g., 'Home > Specialization Name > Course Name'). This provides a consistent mental model and allows users to jump up a level at any time, similar to Amazon's category breadcrumbs.

Finding 3: Silent Failures on File Uploads

Location: Peer Graded Assignment Submission Page

Severity: 3 / 4

Heuristic(s) Violated: Visibility of system status; Help users recognize, diagnose, and recover from errors

Elaborated Description:

When uploading a PDF or image for peer review, if the file size exceeds the limit or the network drops, the system sometimes fails silently or displays a generic red 'Upload Failed' text without explaining why. Nielsen states that error messages should 'precisely indicate the problem, and constructively suggest a solution.' A generic failure message violates this, leaving users frustrated and unsure if they should compress the file or check their internet.

Screenshot Reference:

[Screenshot: Cropped view of the upload dropzone displaying only a generic red 'Upload Failed' text with no further explanation.]

Suggestion for Improvement:

Display a clear, constructive error message stating the exact reason (e.g., 'Error: File size is 15MB, which exceeds the 10MB limit. Please compress your PDF and try again.'). Additionally, display a progress bar during the upload to satisfy 'Visibility of system status'.

Finding 4: Difficulty Retrieving Saved Video Notes

Location: Video Player / User Profile Dropdown

Severity: 2 / 4

Heuristic(s) Violated: Flexibility and efficiency of use

Elaborated Description:

Coursera allows users to highlight transcripts to save notes. However, accessing these saved notes later requires digging through multiple menu layers or navigating back to the specific video. Nielsen's 'Flexibility and efficiency of use' heuristic encourages accelerators that speed up the interaction for frequent actions. Because active learners review notes constantly, hiding this feature behind a convoluted path makes the platform highly inefficient for studying.

Screenshot Reference:

[Screenshot: Screenshot of the user profile dropdown and dashboard, highlighting the absence of a quick link to 'Saved Notes'.]

Suggestion for Improvement:

Add a global 'My Notes' or 'Bookmarks' shortcut directly in the top global navigation bar. Platforms like Medium or Pocket use a simple bookmark icon in the top right, allowing users to jump directly to their saved content from anywhere.

Finding 5: Intrusive Video Autoplay

Location: Video Player End Screen

Severity: 2 / 4

Heuristic(s) Violated: User control and freedom

Elaborated Description:

At the end of a lecture, the next video begins automatically after a very brief 3-second countdown. If a user is taking notes or trying to pause to read the final slide, they must scramble to hit 'Cancel'. Nielsen's 'User

control and freedom' heuristic dictates that users often choose system functions by mistake and need a clearly marked 'emergency exit' to leave the unwanted state. Forcing a rapid state change removes user control.

Screenshot Reference:

[Screenshot: Cropped view of the video player end screen showing the aggressive 3-second 'Up Next' autoplay overlay.]

Suggestion for Improvement:

Increase the countdown timer to at least 10 seconds. Furthermore, provide a global toggle switch directly inside the video player settings (like YouTube's autoplay toggle) so users can permanently disable automatic progression if they prefer to pace themselves.